

Stupas and temples

During the third century BCE, religious architecture developed in the Indian subcontinent with three types of structures: monasteries (viharas), shrines (stupas) and prayer halls (chaityas or chaitya grihas). Following changes in religious practice, stupas were gradually incorporated into prayer halls. These reached their zenith in the first millennium CE, particularly in the cave complexes of Ajanta and Ellora (see here).

Evolving from burial mounds, the stupa developed as a brick and plaster hemisphere with a pointed superstructure, often enshrining relics of the Buddha and acting as a sacred centre for rituals. The most famous surviving example is the Great Stupa at Sanchi from the first century BCE. These simple structures later evolved into complex Hindu temples, richly ornamented, often encrusted with sculpture, and sometimes also brightly painted. Noted examples are the temples of Angkor Wat (c.1100) in Cambodia (see here), and Phra Prang Sam Yod in Thailand (c.1300, opposite).

